Route 66 Turns 100: A Road Trip Through a Century of Pop Culture

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America's most famous highway just turned 100. Route 66 was created in 1926, and it still draws travelers who want to drive from Chicago to Santa Monica, California more than 2,000 miles through eight states, past big cities, small towns, and deserts.

The road earned its nickname, 'the Mother Road,' from writer John Steinbeck. His 1939 novel The Grapes of Wrath followed families traveling Route 66 west during the **Dust Bowl**, a time in the 1930s when **drought** and dust storms forced many families to leave their farms and look for work in California. The book won a **Pulitzer Prize** and became a film.

Route 66 has its own soundtrack, too. Songwriter Bobby Troup wrote the famous tune '(Get Your Kicks on) Route 66' in 1946 during a road trip to California. Nat King Cole made it a hit, and singers and bands from Bing Crosby to Chuck Berry, the Rolling Stones, and Depeche Mode have recorded their own versions.

After World War II, family road trips took off, and Route 66 became a screen star. A TV show named Route 66 followed two young friends driving across America in a Corvette. The 1969 film Easy Rider sent three travelers down the highway by motorcycle. In 2006, Pixar's animated movie Cars set its story in Radiator Springs, a made-up town on Route 66, and it inspired a theme-park ride at Disneyland's California Adventure.

The highway was officially retired as a **federal** road in 1985, but its magic never faded. Today, travelers still stop at **retro** diners, roadside motels, and **quirky** roadside attractions. Route 66 expert Michael Wallis, whose 1990 book The Mother Road helped bring the road back, says the road is all about adventure and a peek at a dream.

Word Treasure

Dust Bowl -- A time in the 1930s when drought and dust storms forced many farm families to leave their homes.

Pulitzer Prize -- A top award given each year for great books, reporting, and other writing.

drought -- A long stretch of time with very little rain.

quirky -- Odd and fun in an unusual way.

retro -- In the style of an earlier time, like the 1950s.

federal -- Having to do with the national government of the United States.

Background you need

Route 66 is a famous American highway that runs from Chicago in the east to Santa Monica, California in the west, passing through big cities, small towns, and deserts.

It was built to link the Midwest with the West Coast, giving travelers and families moving west a single road to follow.

Over time it became much more than a road: writers, musicians, and filmmakers turned it into a symbol of freedom, adventure, and the classic American road trip.

Even though it is no longer an official federal highway, people still drive it today to see its retro diners, roadside motels, and quirky attractions.

Break it down

LEAD: Route 66, created in 1926, just turned 100 and still draws travelers driving more than 2,000 miles from Chicago to Santa Monica, California.

KEY EVENT: The road became a lasting part of American pop culture.

+- WHO: Writer John Steinbeck, songwriter Bobby Troup, singer Nat King Cole, and Route 66 expert Michael Wallis

+- WHEN: 1939 for The Grapes of Wrath, 1946 for the Route 66 song, 1969 for Easy Rider, and 2006 for Pixar's Cars

+- WHAT: A novel, a hit song, a TV show, films, and a theme-park ride kept the road famous.

+- WHERE: Eight states, from Chicago to Santa Monica, California, past big cities, small towns, and deserts

EVIDENCE: The Grapes of Wrath won a Pulitzer Prize and became a film; the song was recorded by singers and bands from Bing Crosby to Chuck Berry, the Rolling Stones, and Depeche Mode; Cars inspired a ride at Disneyland's California Adventure.

OPEN QUESTION: Why does a road retired as a federal road in 1985 still draw travelers to its retro diners, roadside motels, and quirky attractions today?

Why it matters

Route 66 shows how a road can shape a country's stories, songs, and movies, and why places tied to shared memories can stay meaningful long after they stop serving their original purpose.

Test what you remember

1. In what year was Route 66 created?

- (A) 1926
- (B) 1946
- (C) 1939
- (D) 1985

2. How long is the drive from Chicago to Santa Monica, California, on Route 66?

- (A) About 100 miles
- (B) More than 2,000 miles through eight states
- (C) About 500 miles
- (D) About 1,000 miles

3. Who gave Route 66 its nickname, 'the Mother Road'?

- (A) Writer John Steinbeck
- (B) Bobby Troup
- (C) Nat King Cole
- (D) Michael Wallis

4. What did songwriter Bobby Troup write in 1946 during a road trip to California?

- (A) Easy Rider
- (B) Cars
- (C) The Grapes of Wrath
- (D) (Get Your Kicks on) Route 66

5. Which movie set its story in Radiator Springs, a made-up town on Route 66?

- (A) A TV show named Route 66
- (B) Easy Rider
- (C) Pixar's animated movie Cars
- (D) The Grapes of Wrath

6. When was Route 66 officially retired as a federal road?

- (A) 2006
- (B) 1985
- (C) 1946
- (D) 1926

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: A 4: D 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Michael Wallis, a Route 66 expert: He says the road is all about adventure -- and a peek at a dream.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):